

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

Even when the accounts she transferred money to bore suspicious names like 'Mittal Enterprises', the scammers convinced her they were masked accounts used by government agencies for security purposes. They made her believe that her every move, even that of her iris, was under surveillance.

As the hours dragged on, Jain's doubts began to resurface. Borrowing her mother's phone, she messaged a friend, cautiously asking if the Enforcement Directorate operated in this manner. Though still fearful, she refused the caller's demand for another Rs 3 lakh, funds she was to unlock from her Provident Fund. It was then that she realised what was happening.

Abruptly cutting off the call, she sprang into action. Using her banking contacts, she traced the fraudster's accounts and immediately reported the incident to the cybercrime helpline and the Jaipur police. The scammers were already emptying the accounts, but quick police intervention helped her recover the Rs 17 lakh. The investigation revealed a tangled web of multiple accounts, some linked to NGOs in Shimla and firms scattered across the country. Though the money trail was uncovered, the callers remained elusive. Reflecting on the ordeal, Jain admits, "I did question things—like why the CJI would be involved—but it was as if I was hypnotised. They knew exactly how to make me believe them. Even as a banker and lawyer, I fell for it."

-Rohit Parihar

the local authorities are outright complicit. In Cambodia, for example, scam centres operate openly within compounds owned by influential elites. In Laos, the Golden Triangle Special Economic Zone (GTSEZ) has become a haven for illicit activities, including cyber fraud. In Myanmar, border regions like Karen State and Shan State have become notorious for scam compounds, often protected allegedly by local militias and the military. In some cases, these call centres are housed within casino complexes or industrial parks, giving them an appearance of legitimacy while providing protection from local law enforcement. A UNODC (United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime) report estimated that financial losses in 2023 due to cyber-enabled fraud originating from East and Southeast Asia was between $18 billion (Rs 1.5 lakh crore) and $37 billion (Rs 2.9 lakh crore). A USIP (United States Institute of Peace) report from May 2024 says that, as of 2023-end, the annual value of funds stolen globally by cyber scams was an estimated $64 billion (Rs 5.4 lakh crore).

Police say the scammers weaponise emotions—panic at the thought of criminal action, of public humiliation—creating a spiral of fear

The scammers themselves are a mix of local operators, transnational fraud networks and often victims of human trafficking themselves, caught in what has come to be termed 'cyber slavery'. There are three levels in the hierarchy at these call centres—ground-level callers, supervisors and team leaders, and masterminds. Most of those working as ground-level callers are unsuspecting victims lured from countries like India, Nepal and Bangladesh with the promise of high-paying jobs. Upon arrival, their passports are seized, and they are forced to work as scammers in prison-like conditions under constant surveillance. Those who resist face violence, starvation or are sold to other scam operators. The cyber slaves are also subjected to rigorous training in impersonation, psychological manipulation and regional accents to make their calls appear genuine. According to the UNODC and USIP reports, around 300,000 cyber slaves from over 60 countries are trapped in exploitative conditions in these regions (see *A Global Crisis*).

There are many Indians among them, over 5,000 reportedly trapped in Cambodia alone. Government records reveal that of the 73,138 Indians who travelled to Cambodia, Thailand, Myanmar and Vietnam on visitor visas between January 2022 and May 2024, some 29,466 have yet to return.

Alarmed by the scale of the menace, the ministry of external affairs (MEA) has been engaged in high-level talks with the governments of Cambodia, Laos and Myanmar to facilitate the rescue of Indian nationals. Indian embassies in Phnom Penh and Vientiane have aided the repatriation of 828 Indian cyber slaves in Cambodia and Laos. Some of these rescued Indian citizens have revealed how well-oiled the operations are, with separate departments dedicated to recruitment, fraud execution and money-laundering. The supervisors and team leaders are mostly locals from the base countries like Cambodia and Laos who manage the day-to-day operations and monitor the ground callers. At the top of the hierarchy are allegedly Chinese nationals